



*Let the mind manage the body
Que l'esprit gère le corps*

**MAURITIUS
EXAMINATIONS
SYNDICATE**

**PSAC 2025
ENGLISH (P110)**

EXAMINERS' REPORT

Introduction

The PSAC English assessment evaluates candidates' competencies in:

- Reading Comprehension (40%)
- Grammar and Vocabulary (30%)
- Writing (30%)

The assessment objectives align with the goals of the National Curriculum Framework (NCF) for Primary Education. The November 2025 paper maintained a balanced distribution of lower-order and higher-order tasks, enabling candidates across the ability range to demonstrate their knowledge and skills.

General Comments

Candidate performance in this year's examination was satisfactory, with approximately 84.68% achieving at least a numerical Grade 5.

Most candidates demonstrated competence in:

- basic reading comprehension
- recognition of familiar vocabulary
- controlled sentence-level grammar tasks

However, as in previous years:

- higher-order comprehension questions posed difficulty.
- word transformation tasks seemed to be challenging.
- continuous writing (Question 9) remains the weakest section.

It is worth noting that most students have acquired the basic skills necessary for further learning. Many demonstrated the ability to read with understanding and write basic English sentences, though there remains a noticeable disparity in achievement levels.

In reading comprehension, candidates performed well in identifying explicit information, regardless of whether the task was at an elementary or advanced level. However, tasks requiring higher-order thinking skills, such as making inferences, providing personal responses to the text, or explaining vocabulary meanings, remained challenging for many.

Tasks assessing common vocabulary were generally handled well. However, greater attention must be paid to the correct spelling of basic vocabulary words. Candidates showed

weaker performance in applying vocabulary knowledge in context and incorporating it effectively in their writing.

Writing continues to be the most challenging skill for students. Many candidates struggled with various writing tasks, whether forming negative and interrogative structures correctly, properly separating sentences, or constructing individual sentences using given words. At a more advanced level, candidates found it difficult to write compositions that demonstrate creativity, grammatical accuracy, a rich and varied vocabulary, and sophisticated sentence structures.

Key Messages

It is necessary to:

- foster a love of reading from an early age to expand vocabulary and develop language awareness
- teach effective reading strategies to enhance comprehension and critical thinking
- reinforce grammar and syntax by teaching core sentence elements (subject, verb, object, adjective, adverb) and emphasising subject-verb agreement
- encourage the use of wider grammatical tools, including determiners, tenses, to build accuracy and fluency
- expose students to a variety of texts and writing styles to inspire creativity and enrich their vocabulary
- encourage the use of dictionaries and digital tools to support spelling and vocabulary development
- focus on strengthening students' writing skills through regular practice and structured support.
- highlight the value of planning and logical structuring before writing an essay
- equip students with revision techniques to improve their writing independently
- promote careful review and self-editing to develop precision and accountability.
- use model texts and exemplary student work to set clear expectations and motivate learners.
- recognise progress and effort through constructive, positive feedback to build confidence.

Specific Comments

Question 1

This question assesses basic reading skills. Candidates were required to match a sentence with its corresponding sentence.

While a majority of candidates successfully attempted this question, some candidates faced difficulties with the following items:

Items posing difficulty		Remarks
(iv)	Somebody is ringing the bell. It might be the postman.	This indicates that a number of candidates may still find it challenging to interpret simple contextual clues and connect actions with their underlying cause when reading short sentences.
(vi)	The dog has seen a cat in the yard. It is barking angrily.	

Question 2

This question evaluates candidates' grasp of various grammatical structures through multiple-choice items. This year, the assessment focussed on:

- Verb tenses (present perfect and future)
- Prepositions
- Pronouns (personal, reflexive, relative/wh-pronouns)
- Adjectives (including comparative and superlative forms)
- Quantifiers
- Conjunctions

The following items were found challenging by a significant number of candidates:

Items posing difficulty		Remarks
4.	The <u>fastest</u> runner of the school won the race.	Some candidates had difficulty identifying the superlative form “ fastest ”, which requires comparison among more than two people. This suggests that a few candidates still struggle to recognise superlative adjectives in context.
6.	The cyclists put their bicycles <u>against</u> the fence.	The preposition “ against ” indicates that the bicycles were leaning or placed in contact with the fence, a meaning that requires understanding of contextual clues within the sentence. This suggests that some candidates still struggle with the accurate use of prepositions of place.
8.	Mary has <u>taken</u> the dogs for a walk.	The present perfect can be confusing due to its structure (have/has + past participle).
9.	The boy to <u>whom</u> the teacher gave the toy is absent today.	Candidates may find the relative pronoun “ whom ” challenging as it is less frequently used in everyday communication. Some may confuse it with “ who ”, which is more commonly encountered.
10.	<u>Unless</u> you hurry up, we will miss the bus.	Some candidates had difficulty understanding the conditional structure introduced by “ unless ,” which expresses a negative condition equivalent to “ <i>if...not</i> .” This may cause confusion when interpreting the meaning of the sentence.

The following steps may help improve candidates' performance:

1. Strengthen the teaching of grammar in context

More practice should be provided to candidates so that they can identify and use grammatical structures for instance, *inter alia*, prepositions, superlative adjectives, relative pronouns, and the present perfect tense through meaningful sentences.

2. Encourage regular reading and exposure to varied sentence structures

Reading short passages, stories and dialogues can familiarise learners with structures that are less common in everyday speech, such as the relative pronoun *whom* and conditional forms like *unless*.

3. Use targeted exercises and formative assessment

Educators may design practice exercises and short assessments that focus specifically on commonly misunderstood grammatical forms. Immediate feedback can help learners recognise and correct their misunderstandings.

Candidates should also be trained to read all the options before choosing the correct answer.

Question 3A

This section tests candidates' knowledge of basic vocabulary used in daily life. The key objective is to encourage vocabulary learning while reinforcing correct spelling.

Each item		Expected Answer	Remarks
(i)	We put our food on it to eat.	Plate	This item was found challenging by many candidates.
(ii)	We use it to wash our hands.	Soap/ Sink	Many candidates struggled with this item although two answers were tolerated.
(iii)	People go there to keep or withdraw money.	Bank	This item was the best done since most candidates seem to be familiar with basic vocabulary words.
(iv)	We use it to lock and unlock doors.	Key	Candidates fared well in this item as it relates to their everyday routine and is a commonly used word.
(v)	People go there to take the plane.	Airport	A significant number of candidates struggled with the correct spelling of the word 'airport'.

Question 3B

This question assesses candidates' ability to understand vocabulary in context through multiple-choice questions. Overall, candidates performed satisfactorily.

Items posing difficulty		Expected Answer	Remarks
1.	The pupils went to the to see the big ship.	harbour	Some candidates were unfamiliar with the word “ harbour ”. This suggests that a number of candidates have limited vocabulary related to places and environments.
4.	The chef usually wears a white while preparing food.	apron	This item was the worst done. A number of candidates appeared unfamiliar with the word “ apron ” and may have confused it with other familiar items of clothing. This indicates limited familiarity with vocabulary related to cooking and occupations.
5.	Patients could hear the of the ambulance from far.	siren	Some candidates had difficulty identifying “ siren ” and selected distractors referring to general sounds rather than the specific warning sound produced by emergency vehicles. This suggests limited vocabulary related to public safety and everyday situations.

The following steps may help improve candidates' performance:

1. Encourage regular vocabulary development through thematic learning

Educators may introduce and practise vocabulary related to everyday objects, places, occupations and animal kingdom through pictures, real-life examples, and short activities to help learners build stronger word associations.

2. Reinforce correct spelling through regular practice

Activities such as spelling exercises, word games, and short dictations can help learners improve their spelling of commonly used words, particularly those that posed difficulty, such as *airport*.

3. Promote reading and contextual vocabulary practice

Learners should be exposed to short texts, sentences, and comprehension activities that allow them to encounter vocabulary in context. This will help them better understand the meanings of words and select the correct answer in multiple-choice questions.

Question 4A

This question measures reading comprehension at an intermediate level, with a focus on locating information. This year, candidates were given a factual text about **Elephants**, and their overall performance was satisfactory.

Candidates demonstrated sufficient control over literal comprehension skills. Compared to previous years, performance improved, with fewer instances of indiscriminate text lifting, which is commendable.

While most questions were answered well, the following proved more challenging.

Items posing difficulty		Expected Answer	Remarks
6.	Two ways elephants use their trunks: (i) (ii)	• To pick up food • To drink water • To spray themselves to stay cool	Many candidates wrongly gave <i>*food / *to eat / *to spray / *to stay cool</i> as answers, resulting in loss of marks.
7.	One quality that elephants are known for:	• Intelligence • Good memory	Many candidates wrongly gave <i>*the largest mammal</i> (from the 1 st paragraph of the text)
8.	Two reasons elephants are endangered:	• Humans destroy their habitats. • Humans hunt them for ivory. • Climate change makes it hard for them to find food and water.	Many candidates gave <i>*deforestation</i> as answer from their prior knowledge which could not be awarded marks.

Question 4B

This section assesses candidates' reading comprehension through a narrative text. The Extended Reading Comprehension task goes beyond literal understanding, evaluating a range of skills, including:

- Locating explicit information
- Determining the meaning of unfamiliar words from context
- Analysing character traits
- Making inferences
- Providing a personal response to the text

This year's passage centered on a bedtime story: *The Talking Fish*. A few candidates struggled with understanding the passage entirely. Overall, performance in this question was consistent with previous sessions.

Questions based on explicit details were well-answered by most candidates. However, questions that required analytical thinking posed significant challenges for many. Only students in higher ability groups demonstrated strong skills in making inferences and reading between the lines.

Items posing difficulty		Expected Answer
6.	At the end of the story, why did Chris help Ted?	The key idea is: - He was grateful to Ted. - Ted had saved him from a witch's spell.
7.	Do you like Mr Florence? Why?	The key idea is: - Yes, because he helped Ted by giving him a cow. - No, because he imposed conditions while helping Ted.
8.	Circle two adjectives from the list below to describe Ted.	kind mean curious selfish friendly
9.	Put the following events in the correct order as they happen in the text.	[4] Mr Florence gives a cow to Ted for three years. 3 Mr Florence leaves without any further question. 5 Ted saves the life of a talking fish. 1 Ted loses his job as a fisherman's helper. 2 Chris comes to Ted's rescue. 4

The following steps may help improve candidates' performance in tasks assessing reading:

1. Candidates must provide precise and concise answers. Copying large chunks of text is unlikely to earn marks.
2. Candidates should focus on specific details from the text and ensure they understand the context of the question. Misinterpreting or misreading the relevant sentence can lead to incorrect answers.
3. Candidates should base their answers strictly on the information provided in the text. Marks are awarded for responses that are clearly derived from the provided passage rather than from candidates' prior knowledge or personal assumptions.
4. Candidates should read the entire passage carefully before attempting the questions. A superficial reading may result in missing key ideas, relationships between events, or important details needed to answer questions accurately.
5. Candidates should pay attention to vocabulary used in context. When encountering unfamiliar words, they should use surrounding clues in the text to determine meaning rather than guessing.
6. For inference questions, candidates should read between the lines and consider characters' actions, feelings, and motivations as suggested by the text. Answers should still be supported by textual evidence.
7. When asked to analyse characters, candidates should base their descriptions on what the character says, does, or how others respond to them in the passage.
8. For sequencing tasks, candidates should carefully track the order of events in the story and avoid relying on memory alone. Re-reading relevant sections can help ensure accuracy.
9. In personal response questions, candidates should express their opinion clearly while linking it to events, characters, or ideas from the text.

Question 5

This question evaluates candidates' knowledge of syntax in writing at sentence level. A variety of tasks were set, including inter alia, separation of words, removing a surplus word from a sentence, putting words in order, positioning of adverbs, adding punctuation marks, transforming into the interrogative form and writing a sentence using given words.

As noted in previous years, a minimal number of candidates could score the best marks. The influence of Kreol Morisien or French syntax was visible in the transformation into the interrogative, in the positioning of adverbs as well as in sentence writing.

The following items were found challenging by a significant number of candidates:

Items posing difficulty		Expected Answer
(iv)	putting the adverb 'hungrily' in the right place. He ate his dinner.	- He ate his dinner hungrily. - Hungrily, he ate his dinner. - He hungrily ate his dinner. The answer which was not given credit was: - He ate hungrily his dinner.
(v)	adding the required capital letters and full stops.	<u>P</u>eter saw a bag under a tree. <u>H</u>e took it to the police.
(vi)	transforming into its interrogative form. Jenny closed the door.	Did Jenny close the door? As in previous years, transforming into the interrogative continues to be a challenge which requires more work in the classroom. Answers which were not given credit included: 1. <i>*Did Jenny will close the door?</i> 2. <i>*Jenny close the door.</i> 3. <i>*Does Jenny closed the door?</i> 4. <i>*Jenny did not closed the door.</i> 5. <i>*Closed Jenny the door?</i> 6. <i>*Jenny will do closed the door?</i> 7. <i>*Jenny did not/didn't close the door?</i> 8. <i>*Is that Jenny closed the door.</i> 9. <i>*Why Jenny closed the door?</i> 10. <i>*Jenny closed the door, doesn't she?</i>

		Candidates are reminded that merely adding a question mark at the end of a sentence is not given credit since the item is asking for transformation of the sentence. The use of question tags, such as "<i>Jenny closed the door, didn't she?</i>", while grammatically correct, is not accepted for this item, as it does not constitute a full transformation into the interrogative form.
(vii)	Write one sentence by using the following words. mountain – to climb – tired	Certain issues were visibly noticeable: 1. In a few cases, the verb "to climb" was inappropriately changed to "a climb" (a noun), which was not accepted based on the criteria stating that the category of the word cannot be changed. For instance, <i>*I was tired after the exhausting climb to the top of the mountain.</i> 2. Some candidates used the given words in separate sentences rather than incorporating both into a single meaningful sentence, which was penalised. For instance, <i>*Tim was climbing a mountain when he reached the top he got tired.</i> 3. In some cases, candidates used an equivalent word which is penalised. For instance, <i>*The men who climbed the mountain were very exhausted.</i> 4. A majority of candidates are still struggling with the correct syntax, grammar and punctuation. Candidates are reminded that: • The sentence must be meaningful, with correct syntax, and must use all given words in the same sentence. • Verb conjugation must be accurate, and the word class must not be altered. • Up to 2 or 3 non-critical mistakes are tolerated depending on sentence length, but the sentence must retain meaning and grammatical structure.

The following steps may help improve candidates' performance in tasks assessing knowledge of syntax in writing at sentence level:

- 1. Reinforce correct sentence structure:** Provide regular practice on word order, especially for adverb placement, ensuring learners understand where adverbs (e.g. *hungrily*) should be positioned in a sentence.
- 2. Strengthen understanding of interrogative forms:** Teach and drill the correct use of auxiliary verbs (*do/does/did*) and subject-verb inversion when transforming statements into questions.
- 3. Focus on punctuation and capitalisation:** Encourage consistent practice in adding capital letters and full stops to reinforce basic writing conventions.
- 4. Emphasise word class accuracy:** Train candidates to use given words in their original form (e.g. verb remains a verb) and avoid changing them into different word classes.
- 5. Promote meaningful sentence construction:** Guide students to combine all given words into one clear, grammatically correct sentence, avoiding fragments, repetition, or use of synonyms instead of the required words.

Questions 6A and 6B

This question is a higher order reading task assessing the use of language which requires the ability to rely on the context to guess the suitable word, to fill in the gaps. Thus, to be able to work out this question, candidates need to have substantial grasp of receptive and productive vocabulary.

In Part A, candidates had to fill in the gaps with appropriate words from the list of words given. A satisfactory performance with the majority scoring about 5 marks could be observed in this segment of the question.

In Part B, the gaps had to be filled in with words from candidates' own knowledge. It was noted with concern that a significant number of candidates failed to obtain even one mark in this task.

Items posing difficulty		Expected Answer	Remarks
3	He still looked fresh he had stored water.	as / because / since / and / for	Some candidates failed to identify the causal link in the sentence and used inappropriate connectors, showing difficulty in using context to select a suitable conjunction.
4	The rose was ashamed of herself and she asked the cactus if she could have some water.	shyly / gently / politely / kindly / then / even / finally / immediately / sadly / guiltily / humbly / softly / reluctantly	Although a wide range of adverbs was accepted, many candidates were unable to choose an appropriate word to reflect the rose's feelings, indicating limited vocabulary and difficulty interpreting tone from context.
5	The cactus gladly his help.	offered / provided / extended / volunteered	A significant number of candidates struggled to supply a suitable verb, often leaving the blank unanswered or using incorrect words, highlighting weak productive vocabulary and limited familiarity with common collocations.

The following steps may help improve candidates' performance in tasks assessing the use of language based on the context:

- 1. Develop contextual reading skills:** Train candidates to read the whole sentence (and surrounding text) carefully to identify clues such as cause, emotion, and sequence before selecting a word.
- 2. Strengthen vocabulary range:** Encourage regular exposure to new words (especially connectors, verbs, and adverbs) through reading and targeted vocabulary exercises.
- 3. Focus on collocations and word usage:** Help candidates learn common word combinations (e.g. *offer help*, *ask politely*) to improve accuracy in gap-filling tasks.
- 4. Encourage independent word retrieval:** Give frequent practice in open-ended gap-fill tasks (without word lists) to build confidence in using their own vocabulary.

Question 7A

This question assesses candidates' knowledge of grammar and spelling in context. A short text with grammatical and spelling mistakes which had been underlined was set and those mistakes had to be corrected.

This question, one of the higher order tasks, was considered challenging by a vast majority.

Each item		Expected Answer	Remarks
1	There <u>were</u> ...	was	This item assessed knowledge of subject-verb agreement, a fundamental rule of English grammar. It was encouraging to see that this was the best done item in this question.
2	He sat under a tree and <u>waits</u> ...	waited	This item assessed the correct use of past tense in a sentence containing two verbs referring to the past. Many candidates showed difficulty in maintaining tense consistency. To improve, candidates should practise identifying the tense of a sentence and ensuring all verbs agree in time.
3	He then took out <u>her</u> ...	his	This item tested the correct use of possessive pronouns. A number of candidates indicated uncertainty in pronoun agreement. To improve, candidates should practise matching possessive pronouns correctly with the subject.
4	... he was playing hide and <u>sick</u> ...	seek	This item assessed correct spelling of a common expression. Many candidates misspelt the word. To improve, candidates should be exposed to common expressions and practise accurate spelling in context.

5	The story was so <u>interested</u> ...	interesting	This item tested the distinction between <i>-ed</i> and <i>-ing</i> adjectives. Many candidates used <i>*interests</i> instead of <i>interesting</i>, showing confusion between describing feelings and describing things. To improve, candidates should practise the use of <i>-ed/-ing</i> adjectives in context.
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Question 7B

This question assesses candidates' knowledge and application of word transformation rules in English. A short text was set with words requiring transformation within brackets.

A majority displayed a grasp of common word formation rules. However, items 1, 2, 3 and 4 were the poorly performed ones.

Items posing difficulty		Expected Answer	Common Incorrect Answer	Remarks
1	She is always very ... (care) when she does her homework.	careful	<i>*caring</i>	Candidates were required to transform the noun <i>care</i> into the adjective <i>careful</i> . Many selected an inappropriate form, showing confusion between different word forms.
2	She always checks her work twice before ... (to give) it to her teacher.	giving	<i>*given</i> / <i>*giveing</i>	This item assessed the use of the gerund after a preposition (<i>before</i>). Many candidates used incorrect verb forms or misspelt the word.
3	One day, she made a mistake in her ... (spell) test.	spelling	<i>*speaking</i> / <i>*spellin</i>	Candidates were required to form a noun from the verb <i>spell</i> . Many used incorrect or unrelated words, or misspelt the correct form.

4	She felt a bit ... (embarrassment).	embarrassed	<i>*embrased / *embarrassin</i>	This item required transforming the noun <i>embarrassment</i> into the correct adjective <i>embarrassed</i> . Many candidates struggled with both word formation and spelling.
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The following steps may help improve candidates' performance in such tasks:

1. Practise word formation rules: Provide regular exercises on changing words from one form to another (e.g. noun → adjective, verb → noun) to strengthen understanding of parts of speech.

2. Reinforce use of verb patterns: Teach common structures such as using *-ing* forms after prepositions (e.g. *before giving*) and ensure learners apply them accurately.

3. Build spelling accuracy: Encourage consistent practice of commonly misspelt words and patterns (e.g. *-ing*, double consonants) through dictation and writing tasks.

4. Expand vocabulary knowledge: Expose candidates to a wide range of words and their different forms in context to improve both recognition and usage.

5. Encourage contextual awareness: Train candidates to read the whole sentence carefully to determine the correct word form needed based on meaning and grammatical function.

Question 8A

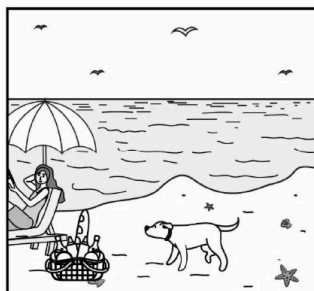
The question assesses candidates' ability of using simple cohesive devices such as adverbs of time, manner or place or coordinating conjunctions to write a short but coherent text.

Three pictures and a set of words alongside were given.

Candidates were required to use the given words in order to write one sentence on each picture while making sure that their three sentences made up a coherent story.



yesterday – beach



suddenly – dog



unfortunately – to steal

Marks	Criteria
2 marks	- Given word used + Meaningful sentence + Coherent to image (appropriate vocabulary and correct syntax - no important word missing e.g <i>determiner, preposition</i> etc.) - Tolerate copying mistakes of given words.
1 mark	- Word used + Meaningful sentence + coherent to image but up to 2 mistakes (<u>sentence up to 8 words</u>) - Word used + Meaningful sentence + coherent to image but up to 3 mistakes (<u>sentence more than 8 words</u>) - Word used + Meaningful sentence but not coherent to image (<u>sentence has to be grammatically correct</u>) Copying mistakes of given words not penalised. Given word replaced by an equivalent one counts as 1 mistake Consequential errors marked as one mistake A minor vocabulary mistake which does not disrupt the meaning of the sentence.
0 mark	- Sentence which is not meaningful - Incorrect syntax - Not English vocabulary (French / Creole word or word which does not exist) - Words given not used
- Ignore punctuation mistakes. - Words given can be used in any order. - Verbs are given in the infinitive form and can be conjugated using any appropriate tense. - Nouns can be used in both the singular and plural forms. - The category of the word cannot be changed (for example, noun to adjective, etc) - Do not penalise spelling mistakes while copying given words. - Sentences are marked individually and repeated mistakes are only considered within the same sentence and not across sentences. - If 2 sentences are used, but if the given words are used in the same sentence mark the sentence normally. Syntax refers to the correct order of words in the sentence. Incorrect syntax e.g - Important word missing/ Incorrect order of words / Addition or omission of a preposition in the sentence structure where it is expected/ not expected is a syntactical error.	

The main issues noted were:

- Some candidates used the given words in different sentences.
- In some cases, candidates wrote correct sentences omitting one of the words given.
- A few candidates wrote syntactically correct sentences with the given words but these did not match the pictures.
- A great majority of candidates wrote lengthy sentences with very frequent grammatical and syntactical mistakes.

The following sample is an illustration of the strengths and weaknesses encountered in this year's paper.

Examples	Marks awarded	Remarks
Yesterday, Norah went to the beach.	2	Awarded full marks as the sentences were meaningful, syntactically correct, used the given words appropriately, and were coherent with the images. No important word was missing, and vocabulary was appropriate.
Suddenly, a dog started to bark at her.	2	
Unfortunately, the dog stole Norah's bread.	2	
Yesterday Mina goes to the beach with his umbrella and baskets full of food.	1	This sentence was meaningful but not entirely coherent with the image as the incorrect pronoun <i>*his</i> was used instead of <i>her</i> , and there was a grammatical error in tense (<i>*goes</i> instead of <i>went</i>). The sentence showed understanding but contained more than one inaccuracy.
Suddenly a dog will coming.	1	This sentence was meaningful and somewhat coherent with the image, but it contained incorrect syntax in the verb phrase (<i>*will coming</i> instead of <i>came</i> or <i>was coming</i>).
Unfortaunately the small dog steal the food and run away.	1	This sentence was meaningful and coherent with the image, but it contained several errors,

		including incorrect tense (<i>*steal, *run</i> instead of <i>stole, ran</i>). Despite these errors, the message remained understandable.
Yesterday Mrs Sarah when to the beach.	0	This sentence was not credited due to incorrect syntax and a spelling error (<i>when</i> instead of <i>went</i>), which affected clarity.
Suddenly the dog it came into the girl's bag.	0	This sentence contained incorrect syntax, particularly the unnecessary repetition of the subject (<i>the dog it</i>). The structure of the sentence was therefore not acceptable despite some relevance to the image.
Sarah saw this and chased it unfortunately the dog stole the her sandwich.	0	This sentence showed some understanding of the situation but was not credited due to multiple syntactical errors, including incorrect word order (<i>the her sandwich</i>) and lack of proper sentence structure. The errors significantly affected grammatical accuracy.

To improve performance in Question 8A:

1. **Reinforce sentence structure** by regularly practising subject–verb agreement and correct word order to ensure grammatical accuracy.
2. **Use picture-based exercises** to train candidates to write sentences that are clearly relevant and coherent.
3. **Emphasise accurate use of given words**, encouraging candidates to form short, clear sentences rather than long ones with frequent errors.
4. **Develop cohesion skills** by practising simple linking devices (e.g. *then, suddenly, after that*) and encouraging natural expression.

Question 8B

This question assessed candidates' ability to use linking words appropriately through the transformation of simple sentences into complex ones.

The performance on this task suggests that candidates are still struggling with the skill of writing complex sentences using conjunctions and relative pronouns.

To be able to earn full marks in this question, candidates are expected to demonstrate the correct use of the linking word while focussing on all other transformations required in order to have syntactically and semantically correct sentences.

The main issues that entailed the loss of marks were:

- Several candidates used the linking words correctly and made all the necessary changes but left full stop between clauses.
- In a few cases, linking words were correctly used but capital letters in the middle of a sentence could be seen.
- The omission of key words led to incorrect sentences.
- The repetition of clauses resulted in loss of marks.

1	Ray takes music lessons. Ray wants to become a great singer. (because)	Marks	Remarks
	1. Ray takes music lessons because he wants to become a great singer.	1	Correct answer
	2. Ray takes music lessons because Ray wants to become a great singer.	1/2	Repetition of clause 'Ray'
	3. Because Ray wants to become a great singer, Ray takes music lessons.	1/2	Repetition of clause 'Ray'
	4. Because ray wants to become a singer, he takes music lessons.	1	'ray' is considered as a copying mistake which is not penalised.
	5. Ray takes music lessons because want to become a great singer.	0	Incorrect syntax due to the omission of the key word 'he'
	6. Ray takes music lessons because Ray want to become a great singer.	1/2	Repetition of clause 'Ray' and 'want' is considered a copying mistake
	7. Ray takes music lessons, Because Ray wants to become a great singer.	0	Repetition of clause and use of capital letter in the middle of a sentence
	8. Ray takes music lessons Ray wants to become a great singer.	0	Omission of 'because'
	9. Because Ray takes music lessons he wants to become a great singer.	0	The meaning of the sentence has changed.
	10. Because ray takes music lessons wants to become a grat singer.	0	Incorrect syntax
	11. Ray takes lessons because he wants to become a singer.	1	Although there is omission of words, full mark is awarded since the omitted words are not key words.

2	Ray's teacher is a famous singer. She often helps him to practise his singing. (who)	Marks	Remarks
	1. Ray's teacher who is a famous singer often helps him to practise his singing.	1	Correct answer
	2. Ray's teache who often helps him to practise his singing is a famous singer.	1	Correct answer despite the mistake 'teache' which is considered a copying mistake
	3. Ray's teacher is a famous singer who often helps to practise his singing.	0	Link word correctly used but omission affects meaning (key word missing: "him")
	4. Ray's teacher is a famous singer who, she often helps him to practise.	0	Incorrect syntax due to the repetition of subject ("she")
	5. Who Ray's teacher is a famous singer she often helps him to practise his singing.	0	Incorrect syntax
	6. Ray's teacher who's a famous singer often helps him to practise his singing.	1	Correct answer
	7. Ray's who teacher is a famous singer often helps him to practise his singing.	0	Incorrect syntax
	8. Ray's teacher is a famous singer who she often helps him to practise his singing.	0	Incorrect syntax
	9. Ray's teacher who is a famous singer, often helps him to practise his singing.	1	Correct answer
	10. Ray's teacher who often helps him to practise his singing, is a singer.	1	Correct answer
	11. Ray's is a famous singer who often helps him.	0	Incorrect syntax due to omission of key words

3	The school organises music shows. Ray participates in them. (when)	Marks	Remarks
	1. When the school organises music shows, Ray participates in them.	1	Correct answer
	2. The school organises music shows when Ray participates in them.	0	The meaning of the sentence has changed.
	3. Ray participates in them when the school organises music shows.	1	Correct answer
	4. Ray participates in the music shows when the school organises.	0	Incorrect syntax due to omission of key word 'them' at the end of the sentence
	5. When the school organises a music show, he participates in them.	1/2	Incorrect agreement -> a music show - them
	6. When Ray participates in them, the school organises music shows.	0	The meaning of the sentence has changed.

4	Ray is improving day by day. Ray is becoming more confident. (and)	Marks	Remarks
	1. Ray is improving day by day and becoming more confident.	1	Correct answer
	2. Ray is improving day by day and is becoming more confident.	1	Correct answer
	3. Becoming more confident Ray is improving day and day.	0	Incorrect syntax
	4. Ray is improving day by day and he becoming more confident.	0	Incorrect syntax

Question 9

Question 9 assesses candidates' ability to write a coherent piece of continuous prose. It assesses higher order writing skills, especially, candidates' ability to:

- develop a given storyline creatively and coherently
- use accurate grammar to express themselves
- use varied sentence structures and
- use rich and appropriate vocabulary

This year, a guided composition was given:

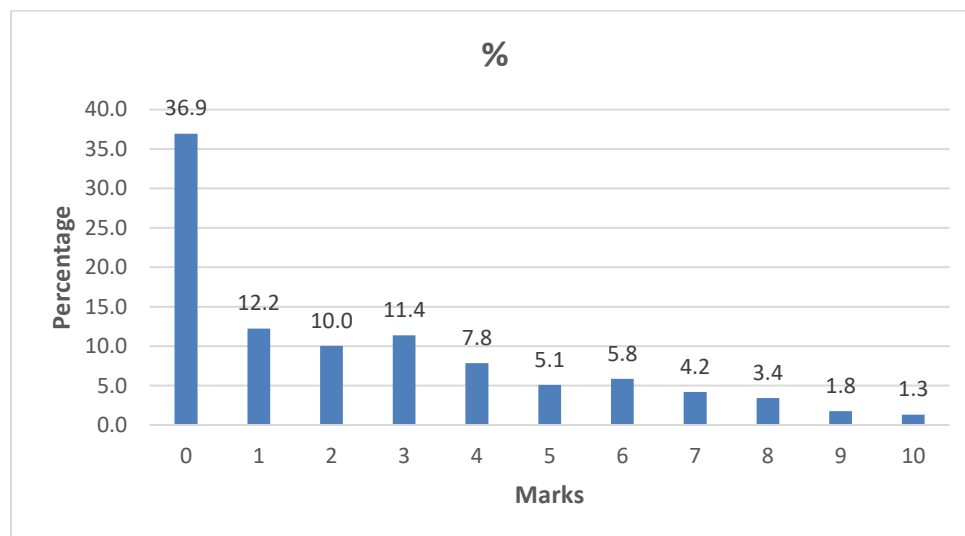
While you were walking to your classroom, you saw a teacher fall and get injured.

Write a story of about 120 words to say what happened on that day.

The following prompts had been given to guide candidates:

- **How did the teacher fall?**
- **How did you feel?**
- **What did you do?**
- **What happened in the end?**

Performance on this question was, on the whole, disappointing. The chart below reveals that an alarming 78.3% of candidates scored between 0 and 4 marks, with 36.9% scoring 0. As noted last year, a significant number of candidates left the question unattempted. This suggests a lack of preparation for the writing question.



Other pertinent issues came to the forefront:

- A significant number of candidates dwelled on lengthy introductions which often did not address the question.
- In some cases, rehearsed pieces of writing were produced which could not be given due credit due to lack of relevance.
- In some cases, candidates did not pay attention to the key words in the question (*while you were walking to your classroom, you saw a teacher fall, get injured*) and wrote lengthily about somebody falling down on the road.
- Candidates struggled with:
 - the coherence of tenses (mixing present and past tense inappropriately)
 - subject-verb agreement
 - the correct use of direct and indirect speech
 - repertoire of vocabulary words
 - the correct syntax due to KM/KR/French interference
 - spelling and punctuation
 - structure and paragraphing (producing sentences instead of a composition in continuous prose)

The following sample of compositions is an illustration of the strengths and weaknesses encountered in this year's paper.

Composition 1

It was a bright Monday morning. The sun was shining britely in the sky. I was walking in the classroom talking. Befort the teacher is coming. Suddenly my teacher fall on the forll. I was scces of my life. We terued to help out teacher Mr John. I rues to call someone and terued to farul Mr John so we call a meimedi and wited for ten min he do not come comed Mr Sam pull him in his new red car. The roca was borulx after fouty five min. There have avarue to the hollpe. Tue doruge give he some meilees and after fifty five min. Thank have come back and we stap work. He fell a againg and we throw some water on his fact. He tiucoles us and drink his meilpes.

134 words

This composition is barely relevant. As for the language, it is clumsy and uncertain throughout, making it difficult for readers to decipher what the candidate wished to express. In addition, the essay is replete with numerous grammatical and orthographical mistakes which implies that it can only score poorly.

Composition 2

1. One Monday morning I going to my classroom and I saw a teacher fall.
2. The teacher fall because she has hard hand douler.
3. The teacher who fall was Miss Hamma.
4. I say my teacher Mr Nawaz she fall down.
5. When he listing me, he go to the who Mr Babouram.
6. Mr Babouram called the same and the girl of Miss Hamma.
7. When same comeing the seport Miss in the ambulance and go to the hospital.

88 words

This composition shows limited relevance to the task and lacks a clear, coherent sequence of events. The ideas are presented in simple, disconnected sentences, for example, “One Monday morning I going to my classroom and I saw a teacher fall” and “The teacher fall because she has hard hand douler,” which make the narrative difficult to follow. There is also inconsistent and incorrect use of tense throughout, such as “I say my teacher Mr Nawaz she fall down” and “When he listing me, he go...,” which further confuses meaning.

Frequent grammatical and spelling errors, including “douler” (pain), “listing” (listening), and “comeing” (coming), significantly reduce clarity. Vocabulary is very limited, and punctuation is weak or missing in places, affecting readability. In addition, sentence construction is poor, and there is little evidence of a developed storyline or effective linking of ideas.

As the composition is also below the required word limit and lacks sufficient development, it can only be awarded very low marks.

Composition 3

One Monday morning I was walking towards my classroom. Suddenly I saw Mr Tom getting knocked down against the wall and he was not waking up. I hesitated to help him as he was far the worst teacher I ever had and I hated him. Even my mother hated him. But unfortunately for me I was forced to help him as I couldn't leave him like that. I started shouting for my other classmates to come and help him to get up. At first they started laughthing as they all hated him too. Then I was chosen to splash water on him to wake him up. I accepted with grate plesure. He was shocked but we all rocked.

118 words

This composition is relevant to the task and presents a clear sequence of events, beginning with "One Monday morning I was walking towards my classroom" and moving logically to the incident where "Mr Tom [was] knocked down against the wall." The narrative shows some attempt at development, particularly in the description of the narrator's hesitation, for example, "I hesitated to help him as he was far the worst teacher I ever had," which adds a personal and engaging element to the story.

However, there are several language and expression issues that affect the overall quality. There are noticeable spelling errors such as "laughting" (laughing), "grate plesure" (great pleasure), and "plesure," which weaken accuracy. Some sentences are awkwardly expressed or unclear, for example, "I was forced to help him as I couldn't leave him like that," and "He was shocked but we all rocked," the latter being informal and inappropriate in tone. Vocabulary is quite basic and repetitive, with frequent use of "hated," which could be replaced with more varied expressions.

Additionally, punctuation is mostly correct, but sentence structure is often simple and lacks variety. While deserving some marks for being relevant, this work scores below average marks, particularly due to insecurity shown in the use of language. With improved spelling, more careful sentence construction, and a wider range of vocabulary, this composition could be more effective and achieve a higher mark.

Composition 4

One day while I was walking to my classroom, I saw a teacher fall and get injured. He fell because a pupil dropped his water there.

I was feeling very sad for the teacher and I decided to go to the headmaster's office. I told the headmaster that a teacher fell and was injured. He then called an ambulance. After some minutes, the ambulance came and took the teacher to the hospital. I was very worried about him.

After some days, the teacher returned to school. He was walking with difficulty. He then thanked me for helping him and he gave me a big gift.

105 words

This composition achieves above-average marks as it remains relevant to the task and follows a clear, logical sequence of events. The candidate develops the storyline appropriately, with clear references to the situation, characters' reactions, actions taken, and resolution, for example, "I told the headmaster that a teacher fell and was injured" and "the ambulance came and took the teacher to the hospital." There is a good sense of coherence, supported by some variety in sentence structures, which contributes to the overall flow of the narrative.

However, a few language weaknesses affect the overall quality. Some sentences are repetitive or simply structured, such as "I was very worried about him" and "He was walking with difficulty," which could be developed further. Vocabulary is rather basic, with frequent use of common words like "very sad" and "big gift," instead of more precise or varied expressions. While punctuation is generally accurate and meaning remains clear, greater control of sentence construction and more varied vocabulary would further enhance the composition and help it achieve higher marks.

Composition 5

While I was walking to my classroom yesterday morning, I witnessed something disturbing. My teacher was hurrying down the corridor when she suddenly slipped on the wet floor and fell. For a moment, I could not think straight. My heart skipped a beat. Then, I ran to her side. "Are you okay, Madam?" I asked anxiously. She shook her head and said, "I think I've sprained my ankle." Without thinking twice, I called a few classmate and together we helped her to the headmaster's office. There, the school nurse examined her and told us that it was not too serious. Although she was shaken, Mrs Atmaram thanked me warmly and gave me a Kitkat from her bag. I finally heaved a sign of relief.

124 words

This is a strong and engaging composition that meets the requirements of the task effectively.

This essay fulfils the objectives of this question which is to produce a piece of work using creativity and imagination while making use of rich and varied vocabulary as seen in this composition: *witnessed something disturbing, My heart skipped a beat, I asked anxiously, heaved a sign of relief*. The composition also demonstrates a good command of complex sentence structures which are used appropriately and consistently.

Overall, it reflects a solid effort that deserves high marks. With greater attention to structure and paragraphing, spelling, punctuation and grammar, this could have been a top-scoring piece.

Composition 6

Helping a teacher is one of the best actions to do. The anecdote which follows is a lucid demonstration.

One day, I was walking to my classroom. Joy furred like spring flowers in my soul as it was my favourite class. At first, everything functioned in perfect harmony. But was I aware of the misfortune that awaits me? I'm afraid not.

Suddenly, while walking, I saw a teacher trip and fall hard on the ground. A wave of pure panic surged through me and I was imprisoned by inexplicable fear. Without letting a second slip, I rushed by her side and asked her if she was hurt. The latter said that she was indeed injured and asked me to call the principal. Without thinking twice, I rushed to the principal's office where I related the situation to him. Shock and panic mingled in his heart on hearing this. He quickly called an ambulance and went to check on the teacher who was still on the floor. After a lapse of five minutes, the ambulance arrived and took the teacher to the hospital where she received medical treatment.

As for me, the principal said that he was proud of me and told me to return to class. When I reached there, I explained the situation to my teacher. The latter reassured me that it was alright. An unburdened sigh of relief slipped from my lips and I went to take my seat. An ineffable joy illuminated my soul as I didn't get in trouble. There is not the least shadow of a doubt that this incident will be etched in my mind until I wrinkle.

274 words

This composition is an outstanding piece of work although it goes beyond the recommended word limit. Candidates are reminded of the fact that writing beyond the recommended word length is self-penalising since they might not have adequate time for revision.

Overall, this essay fulfils the objectives of this question which is to produce a piece of work using creativity and imagination while making use of rich and varied vocabulary as seen in this composition, as well as making use of a correct structure and paragraphing.

There are numerous complex sentences used consistently and in a very natural way. All in all, it is as much as can be expected from a candidate at this level and this composition scores very highly, although there are some minor grammatical mistakes.